In these narratives, John F. Kennedy's judgement and character are crucial to the peaceful resolution of the crisis, and the removal of the missiles from Cuba. Arthur Schlesinger contended: 'It was this combination of toughness and restraint, of will, nerve and wisdom, so brilliantly controlled, so matchlessly calibrated, that dazzled the world.'[27]

In deception operations, 'dazzled' has a different meaning to the one intended by Schlesinger. Much of what we have learned of how the crisis developed, especially from the presidential recordings, indicates that Schlesinger's assessment is no longer credible.

The transcripts and recordings of the White House meetings have enabled historians to map the debates described in memoirs and testimony against a unique and essentially objective record of what was said. Few members of ExComm emerged with their reputation as witnesses to history intact, as the former librarian at the John F. Kennedy Presidential Library, Sheldon Stern, has demonstrated.[28] Robert Kennedy's *Thirteen Days* provides the most egregious attempt to distort history. In his forensic analysis, Stern has shown that the tape recordings 'fundamentally and irrefutably contradict many of RFK's most important recollections and conclusions'.[29]

When Winston Churchill sat down to write his history of the Second World War, he quipped, 'History will be kind to me, for I intend to write it.'[30] Robert Kennedy worked on his manuscript as he was running for the presidential nomination. When President Kennedy's friend and aide, Kenneth ('Kenny') O'Donnell, read a draft, his response was apparently: 'I thought your brother was President during the missile crisis!', to which RFK reportedly retorted, 'He's not running, and I am.'[31] For Stern, the memoir was 'the capstone of an effort to manipulate the history of the missile crisis to Robert Kennedy's perceived political advantage.'[32] That advantage never came, as assassination robbed him of a chance at the presidency and prevented him from completing the book. That task was left to Theodore ('Ted') Sorensen, who, as will be seen, added a further twist by falsifying a crucial part of the story.

As Sheldon Stern demonstrates, a film 'supposedly based on a book about the declassified White House tapes, instead validates the deceptions